Panel

W: 50 cm; H: 46 cm

Inv. no. 11721





This unusual assemblage of six hexagonal panels arranged around a central hexagon evokes the geometry of a more complete star pattern. The marked contrast between the richly inlaid and carved wood and ivory, and the plain, modern backing suggests that these elements were salvaged from an earlier object and reassembled in their current form. Closer examination of the individual panels, each densely carved in relief with classical arabesques, raises a compelling possibility: the pieces display striking, and indeed nearly identical, correspondences with those of the celebrated minbar of Amir Baktimur (698-99 AH / 1299-1300 CE) in the mosque of al-Salih Tala'i (555 AH / 1160 CE). Having likely been removed, reconfigured, and adapted over the centuries, the panels entered the collection of the Museum of Islamic Art via the waqf (endowment) of Prince Kamal al-Din Hussein (1874-1932), offering a tangible record of both their original Mamluk context and subsequent reuse.

Minbar of Amir Baktimur in the mosque of al-Salih Tala'i the mosque of al-Salih Tala'i (555 AH / 1160 CE, with the minbar added in 698-99 AH / 1299-1300 CE).

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